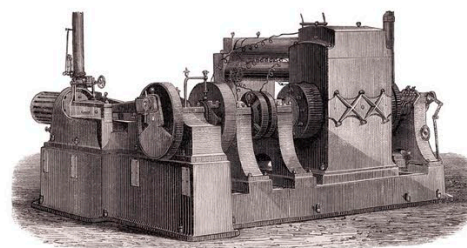




Edison and his colleagues test a new lamp in Menlo Park, New Jersey

CURRENT WARS

In the 1880s, Edison entered into a bitter feud with the electrical engineer George Westinghouse over the best way to provide electrical power. Edison favored direct current (DC) while Westinghouse promoted alternating current (AC). Eventually, Edison had to admit that alternating current was the superior method as it could be sent over longer distances.

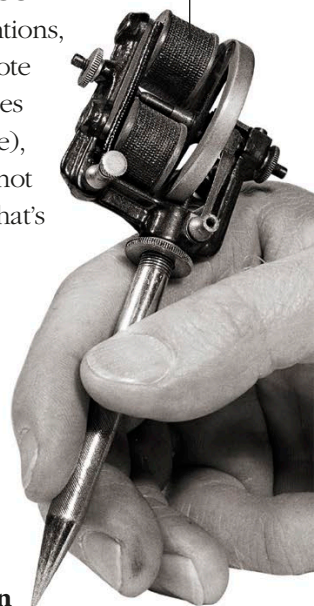


Dynamo (an electrical generator that produces direct current) in the first power plant in the US, built by Edison in 1882

Battery-powered motor

LIMITED SUCCESS

Many of Edison's inventions, including his electric vote counter, concrete houses (with concrete furniture), and electric pen were not successful—although that's not how Edison saw it. While developing the light bulb, he once stated, "I have not failed. I've just found 10,000 ways that won't work."



Edison's electric pen

1879

Following his phonograph in 1877 (see p.204), Edison comes up with a more popular device: the light bulb.

1895

He attaches a phonograph to a kinoscope to create a kinoscope, one of the first sound-film systems.

1904

Edison builds a storage battery for cars, which becomes a huge money-maker.



Edison next to an electric car powered by his battery

1931

He dies aged 84 on October 18. Across the US, companies dim their lights to pay their respects.